

Revolutions

Political revolutions have occurred throughout history and can completely change society. Often violent, they typically occur when angry citizens rebel against their rulers to demand a fairer society, and frequently a different leadership. Revolutions can change existing power structures very quickly. However, their causes have usually been building over many years.

► 1566–1648

DUTCH REVOLT

In 1566–68, Dutch Protestants rose up against Catholic Spain, which had ruled the Netherlands since 1555, and declared independence. The revolt led to a long and bloody war with Spain that ended with Dutch independence in 1648.



MEDAL COMMEMORATING
ENGLISH SUPPORT FOR
THE DUTCH

► 1640–60



ENGLISH CIVIL WAR
TROOPER'S HELMET

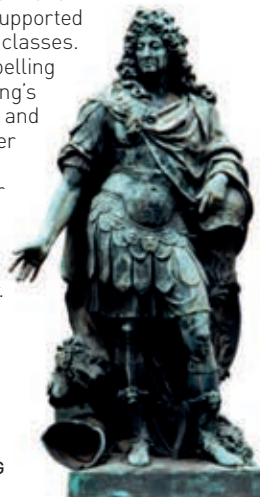
ENGLISH CIVIL WAR

This period of intense political activity started when Parliament wished to restrict the authority of King Charles I. Civil war broke out and ended with the execution of the king in 1649. For ten years, England was a republic ruled by Lord Protector Oliver Cromwell.

► 1648–53

THE FRONDE

A series of uprisings called the Fronde took place in France, initiated by the French Nobility and supported by the middle classes. They were rebelling against the King's absolute rule, and discontent later spread to the masses. After the Fronde failed, the King became even stronger.



STATUE OF KING
LOUIS XIV

◀ 1945



HO CHI MINH:
LEADER OF THE VIET MINH

AUGUST REVOLUTION

In 1945 Ho Chi Minh and his mainly communist force the Viet Minh set out to liberate Vietnam from French rule. They seized Hanoi and declared independence but French forces retaliated. This led to the First Indochina War and the start of bitter conflict in the region.

◀ 1936–39

SPANISH CIVIL WAR

This revolt against the Spanish government led to civil war. On one side were nationalists led by General Franco, backed by Nazi Germany and Fascist Italy. They fought Republicans: Communists, socialists, and anarchists, who were backed by the Soviet Union.



GENERAL FRANCO: DICTATOR
OF SPAIN 1939–75

◀ 1930

BRAZILIAN REVOLUTION

Economic hardship, powerful landlords, and demands for workers' rights led to revolution in Brazil in 1930. A provincial governor called Getúlio Vargas seized power. A dictator at first, he introduced reforms that modernized Brazil and earned him the nickname "Father of the Poor".



GETULIO VARGAS:
BRAZILIAN
PRESIDENT 1930–45,
1951–54

◀ 1918–23

GERMAN REVOLUTION

A series of revolutions shook Germany immediately after World War I (1914–18). Communists Rosa Luxemburg and Karl Liebknecht led the Spartacists' uprising against the government, but it was brutally quashed. Later, extreme nationalists, led by Wolfgang Kapp, tried to seize power, blaming the Weimar Republic for betraying the German Empire.

◀ 1917

STATUE OF LENIN,
BOLSHEVIK LEADER

OCTOBER REVOLUTION

Two revolutions happened in Russia in 1917. The first, in March, removed the tsar (ruler) and set up a provisional government. In the second, in October, the Bolshevik party, led by Vladimir Ilyich Ulyanov (Lenin), called for "peace, land and bread". They seized power and in 1922 set up the Soviet Union, the world's first Communist state.

► 1946–49

CHINESE REVOLUTION

From the 1920s onwards, there was a struggle for control of China between the Kuomintang, or nationalists, led by Chiang kai-Shek, and Communists under Mao Zedong. Civil war broke out in 1945, ending with a Communist victory in 1949.



MAO ZEDONG

► 1953–59



REVOLUTIONARY CHE GUEVARA
BECAME A WORLDWIDE HERO

CUBAN REVOLUTION

An armed revolution led by Fidel Castro and Che Guevara overthrew the USA-backed dictatorship of President Batista. Cuba became a revolutionary socialist state and later a Communist country.

► 1956

HUNGARIAN REVOLUTION

After World War II (1939–45), Hungary became a Communist state, under the influence of the Soviet Union. In 1953 Imre Nagy, a moderate socialist, became leader, and in October 1956 he called for Hungary to become independent in an anti-Soviet uprising. The Soviet troops invaded Hungary and put down the uprising with great brutality.

► 1974

CARNATION REVOLUTION

On 25 April 1974, army rebel tanks rolled into Lisbon, Portugal, and seized control of the city's communications. They overthrew the government of Prime Minister Marcello Caetano, ending 50 years of dictatorship. The revolt was called the "carnation revolution" because the people gave carnations to the troops as they entered the city.

GRATEFUL LISBON CROWDS
PRESENTED REBEL TROOPS
WITH CARNATIONS



► 1974–77

ETHIOPIAN REVOLUTION

In September 1974, Mengistu Haile Mariam led an alliance of radical armed forces and police (the Derg) to depose the emperor, Haile Selassie. They executed the emperor and set up a Communist state. The coup was followed by years of bloodshed and civil war.